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When the House ceases to hold power to account

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A SURYA PRAKASH

THE COUNTRY's democratic institutions — the two Houses of Parliament and the state assemblies — are caricatures of what they used to be when they were established. When it all began in the 1950s, the Houses of Parliament and state assemblies were vibrant bodies that met for around 100 days a year or more, and MPs and MLAs articulated their constituents' concerns. Question Hour and Call Attention Motions kept the government on its toes, and ministers viewed an approaching session with some trepidation. Today Parliament and the assemblies hardly meet, and the disruptive nature of politics has hollowed out these institutions. As a result, they no longer serve the purpose for which they were established.

The two Houses of Parliament met for an average of 127 days per year during the 1990s, and this rose to 138 sittings in the following decade. Now, this average was just 55 days during the 17th Lok Sabha (2019-2024). The percentage of time lost to disruptions has spiralled to over 50 per cent.

There are fewer days for Question Hour, Call Attention Motions, debates on the Demands for Grants of various departments and legislative business. In earlier decades, MPs would put down ministers during Question Hour, and the Speakers would pull up ministers who were unprepared or tried to mislead the House. Today, since the House hardly meets, most ministers are given a walkover.

The performance of state assemblies is even more abysmal. The average sittings of state assemblies per year, around 60 days or more six decades ago, has crashed to less than 25 days. Article 194(1) of the Constitution stipulates that there shall not be a gap of six months between two sittings. Most chief ministers merely ensure that they fulfil this constitutional formality.

This is borne out by PRS Legislative Research. The UP Assembly, which met for 45 to 50 days a year six decades ago, now meets for 15-20 days. The Karnataka Assembly met for around 75-80 days in the 1970s. Now, its sittings average 25 to 33 days per year. The Tamil Nadu Assembly is down from 64 days per year to 32

days. Punjab and Haryana are down to 10-15 days from 40; Bihar is down from 60 days a year to 30. The numbers for Maharashtra, Gujarat and Tripura have fallen by 50 per cent as well.

The problem extends to every aspect of the work of a legislative body, including committees and law-making. Studies show the attendance in committees is just about 50 per cent. The lone talk about the attitude of MPs to law-making, the better. Here are a few examples. On August 31, 2012, the Lok Sabha passed the AIDS (A) Bill concerning the establishment of six such premier hospitals for Rs 4,000 crore, in just a minute-and-a-half. On September 3, 2012, the Lok Sabha passed three bills, including the Protection of Women Against Sexual Harassment at Workplace Bill (a law that affects millions of working women), without debate. One bill about three new high courts in the Northeast was moved at 12:01 and passed at 12:08. The next day the House passed the NDMTANS Bill in two minutes.

In the Monsoon Session this year, two bills were cleared in three minutes each. Three other bills took four minutes each. These examples of "law-making" in Parliament should shake the conscience of every parliamentarian.

The list of perquisites given to parliamentarians is very long, but one item should alert citizens — special, privileged allotment of firearms to MPs by the Customs Department. Four decades ago, Parliament was informed that over 15 months, as many as 38 MPs were allotted guns seized by the Customs Department. KTI activist Anshul Pandey found that 52 MPs were allotted weapons between 2001 and 2012, including 13 who were facing criminal charges like murder, attempt to murder and kidnapping.

In the 1950s, it cost Rs 36,000 per day to run Parliament. In 2004, the cost jumped to Rs 1.23 crore per day and in 2012 to Rs 2.2 crore. Now, PRS Legislative Research estimates the cost to be a staggering Rs 6 crore per day.

Irrespective of which party or alliance is in power at the Centre and in the states, the parties occupying the opposition benches do not allow the Houses to function. The chaos caused by slogans shouting results in adjournment.

The fall in standards is precipitous. People must demand that the salaries, allowances and perks of our representatives be cut by 50 per cent until a semblance of accountability is restored. One looks forward to such a resolution being adopted at the next conference of presiding officers.



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Parliamentary Sitings

When it all began in the 1950s, the Houses of Parliament and state assemblies were vibrant bodies that met for around 100 days a year or more, and MPs and MLAs articulated their constituencies' concerns.

The average sittings of state assemblies is 80 days or more six decades ago, has crashed to less than 25 days.

UP Assembly : which met for 45 to 50 days a year six decades ago now meets for 15-20 days

PRS Legislative Research says estimated cost for running house is Rs 9 Crore per day

India to attend session on UN based multilateralism

India to attend session on UN-based multilateralism

EU, Brazil, Kenya, Canada launch grouping beyond 'superpower politics'; the P4M initiative seeks a more representative UN that is prepared for global challenges, including AI and climate change

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India will join a number of countries committed to supporting United Nations (UN)-based multilateralism, away from "Superpower" politics, as External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar was set to attend the "Partners for Multilateralism" (P4M) meeting at the United Nations.

Mr. Jaishankar landed in New York on Monday at the start of the UN General Assembly's "High-Level debate" session. He is due to hold a number of bilateral meetings and multilateral meetings there, and will address the UNGA on September 26.

The P4M initiative, founded by leaders of the European Union, Brazil, Kenya and Canada is expected to make a pitch for the grouping this week.

In a joint editorial, leaders of the four founders said the grouping will support the UN but push for it to be more representative and prepared for global challenges, including AI (artificial intelligence), climate change, health security and digital transformation.

"P4M will support the reform of the UN and other multilateral institutions, to make them more representative, legitimate, effective and trusted," the leaders,

including European Council President Antonio Costa, Brazil President Lula da



Gearing up: Security guards checking IDs of people ahead of the United Nations General Assembly in New York. REUTERS

Silva, Kenyan President William Ruto and Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney wrote in an editorial published in the U.K.-based *Financial Times*.

Mr. Carney had delivered a speech on "Middle powers" coming together at the World Economic Forum in Davos in January, which signalled growing dissatisfaction not just with Russia and China for unilateral moves and conflicts, but with the United States over trade and tariffs, expansionist moves, and the conflict in Iran that have been undertaken during U.S. President Donald Trump's second term.

It is unclear whether India was asked to join the joint message.

India is already part of a number of groups like the Non-Aligned Movement,

India is already part of a number of groups like BRICS and G20 that have similar objectives

BRICS, G20, and G-4 that have similar objectives.

The editorial on Monday pointed to comments by United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres in which he had said that "superpowers are discovering their limits", adding that the P4M grouping believes that the "international community must rediscover the extraordinary potential of collective action".

Mr. Guterres, who demits office later this year, spoke to *The Hindu* amongst five global outlets in U.S., U.K., South Africa,

the Gulf region and India.

"We have superpowers that have not yet recognised that their power has limits and they get into adventures that produce terrible results," Mr. Guterres had said, specifically pointing to Russia, which was still embroiled in the war in Ukraine four years later, while the U.S. is facing "difficulties" with its war in Iran.

'Limits to powers'

"I think it's time for superpowers to understand the limits of their power, and that will help the world become more peaceful," Mr. Guterres said, speaking to *The Hindu* in New Delhi, where he attended the 18th BRICS Summit.

The editorial also said that the 'Partners for Multilateralism', would not create another exclusive bloc or international bureaucracy.

"Its purpose is the opposite: to create a flexible, open framework for countries from different regions and political traditions that are willing to work across divides, to build coalitions for reform and to translate shared principles into practical action," the co-authors wrote, pointing out that 2025 saw the highest recorded number of state-based armed conflicts since 1946, in 35 countries, and highest recorded military spending of nearly \$3 trillion.

India to attend session on UN based multilateralism

'Partners for Multilateralism' (P4M) Summit

The P4M initiative was first outlined by the leaders of the European Union, Brazil, Kenya, and Canada. It was launched to defend international law, promote peace, and ensure inclusive prosperity.

The inaugural summit in September 2026 was co-sponsored by India, Australia, Barbados, Brazil, Canada, Kenya, and the European Union (EU).

Visegrad Group (V4)

V4 (Visegrad Group) is a cultural and political alliance of four Central European countries - Czech Republic, Hungary, Poland and Slovakia.

How will Gaganyaan's crew module deploy its parachutes

How will Gaganyaan's crew module deploy its parachutes?

Why does Gaganyaan need multiple parachutes? How are they tested?

Unnikrishnan Nair S.

The story so far:

Any spacecraft entering the earth's atmosphere will rely primarily on atmospheric drag to lose a significant fraction of its velocity. To gently touch down on land or in the sea, additional decelerating systems like parachutes have to be activated.

The parachute used for crewed space vehicles demands extraordinary engineering with multi-staging, redundancy, high-performance materials and high-pressure packing to reduce storage space.

How are parachutes deployed?

The parachute system contains three types of chutes: pilot, drogue, and main. The pilot chute is a mini-parachute

deployed to pull out wider drogue or main chutes. The drogue chute is deployed early in the descent to stabilise the module and first reduce the velocity. The main chute has a wider canopy and is used in the final phase to reduce the velocity enough to achieve gentle soft-landing conditions.

The crew module's blunt shape creates a turbulent wake in its rear side and the parachute has to be ejected through this wake. The ejection mechanism should ensure the energy imparted to the parachute suffices to cross the wake in the shortest time and deploy the parachute in the far-wake region.

Generally, the parachutes are deployed when the module has reduced its speed to below the speed of sound.

Why deploy parachutes in stages?

As it descends, the Gaganyaan crew

module will be moving at around 170 m/s in the lower atmosphere. If the full-sized main parachute is deployed straightaway, it will experience a high opening shock, shredding the fabric or subjecting the crew to dangerously high deceleration.

Multi-staging, on the other hand, increases the chutes' diameter in successive stages, keeping the dynamic pressure to acceptable levels.

Also, to keep a chute from opening really quickly, a cord wound around the canopy restricts how far it can spread. After a preset delay, when the vehicle has slowed enough, a timed cutter severs the cord, which goes loose and allows the parachute to bloom fully.

How are parachutes tested?

There are different platforms to test parachutes. The 'rail track rocket sled' is a ground facility where a sled is accelerated

along rails by firing small solid motors, and the parachutes are deployed from the sled at an appropriate velocity. The Terminal Ballistic Research Lab, Chandigarh, has a state-of-the-art RTRS facility.

Other modes of testing include dropping the test article from a helicopter or an aircraft or using small rocket-powered test vehicles, which launch the crew module to some appropriate altitude and release it from there.

After splashdown in the sea or upon soft-landing on land, if the parachute is not detached immediately, the wind acting on the canopy could drag the module on land or capsize it in sea and this might cause injuries to the astronauts. Hence, the parachute is released by activating pyro cutters or mechanical quick-release devices.

What materials are used in aerospace parachutes?

A parachute's material is controlled by conditions like tensile strength, thermal resistance, and mass. Modern aerospace parachutes use advanced synthetic polymers engineered to meet specific design conditions.

Kevlar is used in high-load suspension lines, risers, and structural reinforcement tapes due to its exceptional tensile

strength and heat resistance. Nomex finds application in heat-exposed areas to withstand hot mortar gas discharge and aerothermal heating.

Nylon is widely used for canopy broadcloths because of its elasticity, which helps absorb initial dynamic shock loads during inflation. It is highly compressible, so it can be packed into a relatively small volume.

What parachutes are in the Gaganyaan crew module?

In crewed missions, recovery systems use redundant clusters of pilot, drogue, and main parachutes. The Gaganyaan crew module has two drogue chutes deployed by mortars and three main chutes deployed by mortar-ejected pilot chutes.

If one main parachute suffers an anomaly, the remaining two independent chains are fully capable of ensuring a safe touchdown.

ADRDE in Agra, which is a laboratory under the Defence Research & Development Organisation, is the developing agency.

(Unnikrishnan Nair S. is former director, VSSC and IIST; Founding Director, HSFC; and an expert in launch vehicle systems, orbital re-entry and human spaceflight technologies. Currently Dr Sarabhai Professor at VSSC)

How will Gaganyaan's crew module deploy its parachutes

- **Gaganyaan is India's flagship indigenous human spaceflight programme formally announced in 2018.**
- **The mission aims to demonstrate India's capability to send a crew of three astronauts to a 400 km Low Earth Orbit (LEO) for a three-day mission and safely return them through a splashdown in Indian sea waters.**
- **It will establish India as the fourth country, after the United States, Russia, and China, to independently develop and execute a human spaceflight mission.**
- **Human-rating is the comprehensive engineering and certification process that ensures a spacecraft or launch system can safely carry humans into space with an acceptable and extremely low level of risk.**
- **Beneficial for Space Station Development**
- **Vehicle : LVM-3 (GSLV) (Chandrayaan 2&3 were launched using the same)**

Why scientists are rethinking the chemical 'arms race' against fungi

Why scientists are rethinking the chemical 'arms race' against fungi

New research is showing that fungi are protected from antifungals by genetic mutations as well as by making more copies of protective genes, and it seems the idea of dousing fungal pathogens with antifungals is nearing its end; the next generation of antifungals will need more planning

Somdatta Karak
HYDERABAD

For a long time, fungal infections have meant itchy skin, discoloured nails and sometimes hair loss.

These symptoms are collectively called dermatophytosis and are caused by a group of fungi called dermatophytes.

"Unfortunately, immunocompromised patients can get lesions all over their body. The itchiness and the lesions can get so severe that people even get suicidal thoughts," said Shivaprakash Rudramurthy, Professor of medical mycology at the Postgraduate Institute of Medical Education and Research (PGIMER), Chandigarh.

Global warming

Dermatophytes are molds: fungi that grow in long strands. The other common category of fungi is yeasts, which are single, oval-shaped cells. Among the yeasts, *Candida auris* is rapidly emerging as a multidrug resistant pathogen in ICU facilities. It enters the blood stream and causes severe infections, most of which are untreatable by the available antifungals. According to Professor Rudramurthy, those infected suffer a 30%-40% mortality rate.

C. auris has become a menace only in the last two decades. The first report was in 2009 in Japan. Several other fungal species have become more pathogenic only in recent times. The cause of this rise remains unresolved but scientists and medical doctors have some ideas.

Fungi grow best in damp places below 30 degrees Celsius, so they can grow on our skin, especially in moist areas of the body, like armpits and the genital area. However, bloodstream infections in humans were rare because they could not survive in the body's 37 degrees Celsius temperature.

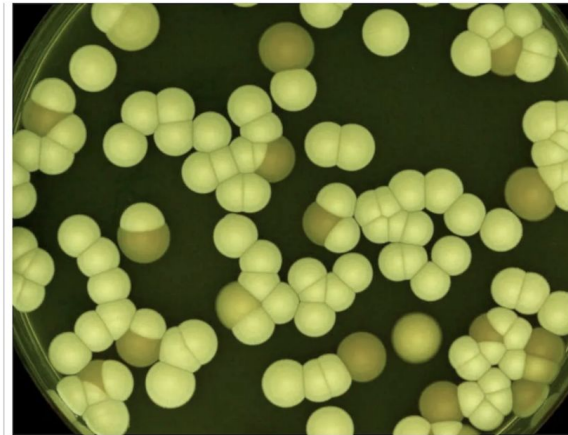
"Fungal infections are common in cold-blooded animals with lower body temperatures," Sritam Varahan, a mycologist at CSIR-Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology, Hyderabad, said.

"But global warming puts a selective pressure on fungi such that only the more heat-tolerant ones survive. These ones can survive inside our bodies too, if they gain access to it. This is called the fungal infection – mammalian selection hypothesis."

Clinical samples

Today, roughly 20% of infections reported in hospitals are fungal in nature – yet most hospitals in India lack the capabilities and infrastructure to identify fungal pathogens, Professor Rudramurthy said. This prompted the PGIMER to begin sorting fungal pathogens some 25 years ago. Today, the institute holds a stock of 15,000 clinical fungal isolates across India and helps other medical centres and clinicians identify and culture them for study, free of cost.

The *C. auris* isolates from the PGIMER's repository have come handy for Kaustubh Chandra and his research group since December



Candida auris growing in a nutrient-rich growth medium. The fungus has become a menace in the last two decades. PHANICANITHIRAI (CC BY)

In a recent study published in *Nature Communications*, they characterised the clinical isolates of *C. auris* found across India. Their focus was the pathogen's ability to resist antifungals. They were able to establish their findings in patient samples and go beyond earlier studies in model systems.

"More than 90% clinical isolates of *C. auris* are resistant to common azole-based antifungals, such as fluconazole," Professor Sanyal said. Some "30% of them are resistant to another class of antifungals called the polyenes. They mostly respond to a different class of antifungals called the echinocandins."

A drug may not work on a pathogen for many reasons, including the drug's target becoming mutated or the drug's effect being negated by the pathogen's own biomolecules. Dr. Narayanan and her collaborators at the Indian Institute of Science Education and Research, Thiruvananthapuram, found significant changes in drug-resistant *C. auris* genomes that could explain why Indian clinical isolates were able to resist azoles and echinocandins.

Susceptibility tests

A fungal cell has two protective layers surrounding it. The outermost is the cell wall and the inner one is the cell membrane. Azole and polyene antifungals target a fat called ergosterol that is enriched in the cell membrane.

eliminating the effect of the azole drug," Dr. Narayanan said. The study found parts in the *C. auris* genome where additional copies of the *Erg11* gene were present.

With echinocandin drugs such as caspofungin, the team found mutations in the *Fks1* gene that allowed the pathogen to resist the drug's action. The team also found genetic changes promoting higher tolerance of echinocandins.

"*Fks1* mutations can enable *C. auris* to survive even caspofungin doses up to 16 ug/ml. That means a patient with such a pathogen will need the drug at a concentration higher than 16 ug/ml," Professor Sanyal said.

"Today, clinicians would not know that because they test the pathogen's ability to survive only until 2 ug/ml of caspofungin – as defined by the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, and followed globally."

The logical thing for clinicians would be to look for mutations like in the *Fks1* gene and decide the limits for tests to decide the antifungal dose for patients. But due to associated costs, a more practical way is to increase the limits of susceptibility tests for caspofungin to higher than 16 ug/ml, Professor Sanyal added.

C. auris, without any specific gene mutation or gene duplication, still responds to high concentrations of caspofungin in unexpected ways. While the pathogen dies at lower concentrations of the drug, at concentrations the body can't

chitin, the raw material of the fungal cell wall, in large quantities. Any damage that caspofungin brings about on the cell wall is compensated by the extra chitin production. And thus the cell wall remains intact despite the antifungal."

Such examples of paradoxical growth are called the Eagle effect, named for the U.S. pathologist Harry Eagle.

Beyond the arms race

The studies underline the importance of clinicians conducting more nuanced susceptibility tests to decide the antifungal doses. They show that fungi are protected from antifungals by genetic mutations as well as by making more copies of protective genes.

Professor Sanyal also stressed on the need for a combination of therapies to target cellular compensatory pathways, keeping the major antifungals effective against drug-tolerant species.

However, Dr. Varahan said he believed scientists and doctors need to think of gentler alternatives. "When we target [a molecule] without which an organism cannot live at all, evolution ensures that its population survives with a changed molecule. So instead of participating in an arms race, it is perhaps better to target the less critical molecular pathways, inhibition of which will allow the pathogen to still survive but not cause a disease." It seems the idea of dousing fungal pathogens with antifungals is nearing its end. The next generation of

Why scientists are rethinking the chemical 'arms race' against fungi

Candida auris

It is a fungal pathogen that is often multi-drug-resistant.

This pathogen can live on the skin, inside the human body (e.g. in the gut), or in the environment.

It is capable of causing invasive infections in the human body.

C. auris causes serious infections such as bloodstream infections, meningitis, bone infections, burns/wound infections, and urinary tract infections.

Most C. auris infections are treatable with antifungal drugs called echinocandins.

However, some C. auris infections are resistant to the main types of antifungal medications, making them more difficult to treat.

Examine the key mechanism available to the Indian Parliament to scrutinise the executive. What are the major gaps in these mechanisms, and how can they be strengthened to uphold the principles of transparency and accountability?
(Answer in 250 words) 15 marks

Thank You